

# Modulation

Modulation means moving from one key to another. This can be done either by changing the music's key signature or by adding accidentals to indicate that the music has moved to a different key.

## SEE ALSO

◀ 64–67 Keys

◀ 70–71 The circle of fifths

◀ 72–73 Accidentals

Degrees of the scale

124–125 ▶

## Changing the key signature

The music usually has a double bar line if the key signature changes. The new key signature is then written after the double bar line. If sharps or flats in the old key signature are canceled, naturals are usually written before the double bar line, but are written after it if the new key lacks a key signature.

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Double bar line can indicate change of key

New key signature for D major

This example shows a modulation from C major to D major. The first staff is in C major (no sharps or flats). A double bar line indicates the change of key. The new key signature for D major (two sharps: F# and C#) is written after the double bar line.

◁ **C major to D major**  
C major has no key signature, so the new key signature for D major is written after the double bar line.

Naturals after double bar line

New key signature of F major

This example shows a modulation from A major (three sharps: F#, C#, G#) to A minor. The new key signature for F major (one flat: Bb) is written after the double bar line. Naturals are written after the double bar line to cancel the sharps from the old key of A major.

◁ **A major to A minor**  
Since A minor lacks a key signature, naturals must be written after the double bar line to cancel the sharps from the old key of A major.

E♮ belongs to both the F harmonic minor and F major scale.

Naturals before the double bar line cancel the three flats from F minor.

New key signature of F major

This example shows a modulation from F minor (three flats: Bb, Es, and Fb) to F major (one flat: Bb). The new key signature for F major (one flat: Bb) is written after the double bar line. Naturals are written before the double bar line to cancel the three flats from F minor. The note E♮ is highlighted, indicating it belongs to both the F harmonic minor and F major scale.

◁ **F minor to F major**  
To cancel the flats from F minor and the new key signature of F major, naturals are written after the double bar line.

New key signature of B major

New key signature of E major

This example shows a modulation from D major (two sharps: F# and C#) to E major (three sharps: F#, C#, and G#). The new key signature for B major (two sharps: F# and C#) is written after the double bar line. The new key signature for E major (three sharps: F#, C#, and G#) is written after the double bar line.

◁ **D major to E major**  
Naturals and the new key signature are written after the double bar line if the key signature changes from sharps to flats.

New key signature of B major

This example shows a modulation from B major (two sharps: F# and C#) to B major (two sharps: F# and C#). The new key signature for B major (two sharps: F# and C#) is written after the double bar line.

◁ **B major to B major**  
Naturals and the new key signature are written after the double bar line if the key signature changes from flats to sharps.